



ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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SPORTS FITNESS DOESN'T DEPEND ON SLIM WAISTS ALONE

Two players, with waists that even their most ardent admirers wouldn't call super slim, had a rollicking partnership of 177, which saved India from the **blushes of an innings defeat** against New Zealand.

If ever proof was required that in sports there cannot be one standard of fitness, it was provided in the first Test match against New Zealand in Bengaluru. **Two players, with waists that even their most ardent admirers wouldn't call super slim, had a rollicking partnership of 177, which saved India from the blushes of an innings defeat.** That their heroics went in vain, as the batters who followed them simply didn't have the technique or temperament to deal with a pitch that was different from the low-bounce ones where they dominate, only added to the frustration.

If anything, the way the Indian batting has struggled in Chennai — where again there was some bounce — and now in Bengaluru, does make one anxious about what lies in store in Australia. Even the flattest of pitches there have more bounce than the usual Indian surfaces. That said, the Kookaburra ball should be an ally of the batters, as once a dozen overs or so have passed, the seam movement is almost negligible and batting becomes a lot easier.

Sarfraz Khan has been denied a place in the Indian team for some years now, despite scoring runs by the hundreds in domestic cricket. This was largely because those in a position to make decisions believed he didn't have the slim waist they deemed necessary for international cricket. Sarfraz's returns on the

field with the bat were even more prodigious than his waistline. Sadly, Indian cricket has had too many decision-makers with ideas that are hard to fathom.

Way back during my playing days, Karsan Ghavri was not picked for the twin tours of New Zealand and the West Indies, apparently because he chewed paan, which wasn't considered appropriate by a highly voluble selector who, throughout his life, only sought to impress his friends at Lord's. It's not just him — many people in India have this strange notion that a slim waist signifies a fit person. How often have we heard someone look at a slim-waisted individual and say how fit they are? **Sports fitness doesn't depend on slim waists alone. If the mind is strong, then physical fitness can largely be controlled by it.**

In any case, what sort of fitness are we discussing in the modern day, where bowlers have a drink waiting for them at the boundary edge after bowling an over, and sometimes even receive a quick shoulder massage between deliveries from the other end? What fitness are we talking about when batters get drinks after every other over, with the reserve player running in, ostensibly for a change of gloves? Not just the batter but even his partner at the other end gets a drink, even if he has just come in to bat a few deliveries earlier. Umpires turn a blind eye to this, feeling that as long as the game isn't delayed, players can